



~~Quain, Inc.~~

~~Quain Identity Partners~~

~~Quain & Assoc.~~

~~Quain Associates~~

~~Quain Brand Studio~~

~~The Quain Company~~

Quain & Company a play by Josh Worth

~~The Quain Group~~

~~Quain Naming & Branding~~

~~QUAIN~~

~~Quain Brand Strategies~~

~~Quain International~~

~~Quian Worldwide~~

~~Quain Global~~

~~Quain & Co.~~

Quain & Company

by Josh Worth

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PEOPLE

QUAIN

INGRID

RAY RAY

KYLER

JIMMER

ANNE / CRISTI

SCENE I

An intentionally casual, open workspace, meant to encourage creativity and collaboration. A smaller enclave is reserved for privacy.

The backstage crew is visible at times, doubling as unnamed employees.

The company is gathered for an all-hands meeting.

QUAIN

If this is the first one of these, for some of you, That's okay. We all start somewhere.

JIMMER

We love virgins!

RAY RAY

Can it.

QUAIN

We need new voices. New words. New ways of constructing, deconstructing and reconstructing this language. That's why we're here. We need to hear how you hear.

JIMMER

Here here.

QUAIN

So we're going to start slow. But first I need you to clear your minds. Find that silent place. That place where no words are popping in and out of your mind's ear. So Ray Ray. How do we get there?

RAY RAY

We word release.

QUAIN.

And how do we do that?

RAY RAY

We expunge.

QUAIN

Right. And what does that entail?

RAY RAY

We expeliorate the words.

QUAIN

Probably best if you just show them.

Pause

RAY RAY

Now?

QUAIN

Go for it.

Ray Ray begins her "word release," letting loose with a quick succession of whatever words pop into her head. The words are deliberate and over-enunciated.

RAY RAY

Albacore. Abracadabra. Elf. Excelsior. Honor.
Honorarium. Femur. Fendibular. Spectacular specimen.
Specific specimen. Splendid specimen. Speciminty.
Helpless Helga. Gargantuan Aorta.

QUAIN

You get the idea?

Ray Ray continues.

QUAIN

Shall we join her?

Pause as the group awaits his cue.

QUAIN

Replicator. Replier. Replenishment. Kentucky.
Marvelous. Juxtapose. Melody. Melodius...

*The rest of the group joins in the exercise, creating
a cacophony of sounds and syllables.*

Ray Ray checks her watch.

RAY RAY

Time.

*It's obvious none of the participants were aware
of the time factor.*

Silence.

QUAIN

You feel that? Let's take another minute of that.

KYLER

Jargon. Kleptomania. Loquacious..

QUAIN

Shh. Shh. No.

Into a whisper.

No no no. That... The silence.

Pause.

Ok. Let's hope those inner voices have quieted down.

He nods to Ray Ray.

RAY RAY

Ok. Splinter groups.

Jimmer, Kyler, Quain and Ray Ray change positions on stage.

QUAIN

Ray Ray. Let's bring it out.

Ray Ray places a white bag in front of them.

RAY RAY

Now?

QUAIN

Now.

From the bag, Ray Ray removes a plastic pill bottle with a blank white label. She walks the bottle around the room, making sure each member of the group gets a good look at it.

She opens the bottle and removes a handful of small orange pills. She hands a pill to each of the participants.

There's a pause while Quain stares intently at the group.

Kyler slowly begins to put the pill towards her mouth. Ray Ray makes an abrupt gesture with a silent "no." Kyler gets the idea and stares down at the pill in her hand.

QUAIN

So this little orange object needs a name. Right now it's a silent nothing. There's no sound in the mind to match what we're seeing. Harper-Kemp Pharmaceuticals has asked us to change that with a name.

KYLER

What does it do?

QUAIN

Everything! The name brings it into existence-

KYLER

I meant the pill?

QUAIN

What does it do? Does it matter what it does?... Yes. It does. Does it matter to us what it does?

Thinking. Nodding.

Yes... Yes. It also matters to us...

Nodding.

So that was a good question. "What does it do?" Ray Ray, do we know what it does?

RAY RAY

Yes.

Pause

RAY RAY

Do you want me to tell them?

Quain nods slowly.

RAY RAY

It's for laryngitis.

QUAIN

There we go. Laryngitis.

RAY RAY

“For the temporary relief of symptoms relating to inflammation of the larynx... Dry raspy throat. Tightened, irritated vocal cords. Strained speech. Hoarseness.”

QUAIN

There we go.

RAY RAY

Side effects may include vomiting, diarrhea, loss of appetite, trouble sleeping, elevated heart-rate...

QUAIN

There we go. Thank you, Ray Ray.

He takes the brief from Ray Ray.

Now... Harper-Kemp Pharmaceuticals is paying us a lot of money to name this little laryngitis pill. A lot of money... They're not stupid. Not at all. They understand that our work here can make or break their product.

He reads the brief briefly.

Now... I don't want to color your thinking too much at this point, but I'll say this: “Clinical... Memorable... Resounding... Celebratory... A single word that resonates with laryngitis sufferers.”

We hear an alert chime coming from the phone in his pocket.

Got that? Good. We're going to start off with a brain dump.

He takes the phone from his pocket and reads the text. Everyone watches. He chuckles and enters the enclave.

Attention turns to Ray Ray.

RAY RAY

Ok. Brain dump time...

The meeting continues silently as the focus shifts to Quain sending a text.

He waits for a minute. He seems uncomfortable, but amused.

A moment later, he is joined by Ingrid. She's carrying a stack of printouts.

Quain attempts a kiss. She turns her cheek and hands him the stack of printouts.

QUAIN

Ok. Gotcha. Logos for Chatterly.

He flips through the pages.

That's rich. Too ornate probably. Great otherwise.

Flips

They'll go for that, obviously. They like that magenta.

Flips

Standard fare. Safe.

Flips

That's got a nice 19th century flair. Flowing. If you can get the magenta in, I think that's a winner. What else?

Flips. Pause.

Well, that's not a logo at all. That's something else, isn't it? Would you look at that? I didn't know you were going in for that.

INGRID

I didn't want to bother you.

QUAIN

Come on. No. I want to be a part of this. You know that right? You know I want to be a part of this.

INGRID

You say that.

QUAIN

I do say that. I say that because I mean it.

INGRID

I just don't think you know the meaning of what you're saying.

QUAIN

I mean I want to be involved. The doctor visits and the classes. Where I say, "Breathe. One two three. Breathe." I want to be there for you and for it... for...

INGRID

Her.

Pause.

QUAIN

Is that what this says?

INGRID

That was the opinion. They can't say for sure but it looks that way from all the angles.

He stares at the paper.

QUAIN

Oh yes. They wrote it on there.

INGRID

It might've been hiding or something.

QUAIN

You mean the—

INGRID

No sign of one.

QUAIN

Right. Why does it matter? At this point it's like a lizard.
A newt. A salamander.

Ingrid is confused.

QUAIN

Right. Why does it matter?

He looks at her.

INGRID

So number four then?

QUAIN

Yes. Number four for sure. Four sure. With the magenta.

INGRID

I'm concerned this is going to get complicated.

QUAIN

How so?

She laughs and shakes her head.

QUAIN

No. Really? How so?

INGRID

People say things.

QUAIN

And what?

INGRID

It's uncomfortable.

QUAIN

Have I said something to make you uncomfortable?

INGRID

This whispering is uncomfortable.

QUAIN

I thought that was the fun. We like the whispering.

INGRID

I did, sometimes. Not like you, but, you know— questions will arise.

QUAIN

Right. Yes. The questions. How do you want to...

INGRID

I don't want to... I don't know. I don't need to make it a—

QUAIN

Hang on now. We don't work that way. This is real. The real deal.

Holding the photo.

INGRID

It doesn't have to be anything. I don't have to...

QUAIN

No. No no no. I'll handle this.

SCENE 2

Kyler and Jimmer are both looking at phones in the common room.

KYLER

This is...

JIMMER

Revolutionary.

Pause.

KYLER

So different.

JIMMER

Refreshing, right?

KYLER

I guess... I didn't even know they were a thing.

JIMMER

Really? How could you not know?

KYLER

You knew?

JIMMER

You don't see that look they have?

KYLER

I just thought that was their look.

JIMMER

More of a smell. I could smell something was up.

KYLER

So you didn't know.

JIMMER

I knew.

KYLER

But you never mentioned it.

JIMMER

You don't talk about that stuff.

Ingrid enters. Jimmer nods approvingly.

INGRID

What?

KYLER

Hey girl. Looking good!

JIMMER

Does she have that shine yet? They talk about that shine.
When does the shine come in?

KYLER

I'm here for you if you want to talk.

JIMMER

We're supposed to talk and be open. I like that.

INGRID

What happened here?

Pause.

KYLER

Did you not get the email?

INGRID

I don't check email until nine thirty.

JIMMER

Wish I could do that.

KYLER

But you knew the email was going out today.

INGRID

Email goes out every day.

KYLER

Oh wow.

JIMMER

You're going to want to break your rule today.

Ingrid fumbles with her phone.

QUAIN

(Reading the email outside the scene)

A joyful announcement: Let it be known that life will go on with or without us. The bodies join together and out

comes the new life. A baby. And with the baby comes joy. The joy of the suckling and the toddling and the blossoming. Let it be known that the prospect of new life is upon us and the time for joy is now. Because one of us among us is carrying new life. And she is Ingrid. And the father is known as Quain. And together they shall usher in the new life and bring forth a time of joy for all among us. And let it be known that as one who is among us, you are entitled to that joy so let our joy be your joy and your joy be ours.

JIMMER

It's refreshing. This whole thing. I can't believe I get to work here.

KYLER

It's inventive.

Ingrid finishes reading. The others stare at her.

KYLER

What are you feeling?

INGRID

Huh. Wow... That's something, I guess.

JIMMER

Right?

KYLER

I just really appreciated the writing.

INGRID

Hm.

KYLER

What. What are you feeling?

INGRID

It's just awkward. I'm sorry.

KYLER

Don't be sorry. It doesn't have to be awkward. That's the whole point. We can de-stigmatize the whole thing.

INGRID

I wasn't feeling stigmatized.

JIMMER

Stigmata can appear supernaturally on the hands of the devout.

KYLER

So it's not all bad.

INGRID

Ok.

JIMMER

You're so precious. I thought you were precious before but now you're extra precious.

INGRID

I don't really want to be precious, if that's ok.

JIMMER

Fine. You're not precious, but that belly thing is.

Ingrid exits.

KYLER

It is awkward.

JIMMER

Pregnancy is awkward.

KYLER

You can't help but picture them all naked getting nasty.

They laugh.

JIMMER

What are you supposed to say? "Hey! Congratulations on the fucking."

KYLER

"Way to let that jizz up your vajayjay and implant itself in your ovum."

JIMMER

"Now here's a \$500 diaper bag."

Ray Ray enters. Jimmer and Kyler compose themselves.

RAY RAY

Ameliorate... Ameliorate.

Ray Ray looks up.

JIMMER

Were you in on this?

RAY RAY

I was aware. Yes.

KYLER

How's the rest of the office taking it?

RAY RAY

Fine.

KYLER

Transparency is nice.

JIMMER

Better than secrets.

RAY RAY

That was the idea, yes.

KYLER

What's wrong with secrets?

JIMMER

Haven't you heard? They eat away at the soul.

RAY RAY

Everything's secret until you talk about it openly.

KYLER

What about just "private?"

JIMMER

Right. Can you have a private secret?

KYLER

Sure. Right?

(Thinking)

"I like to keep my secrets private?"

JIMMER

"I like to keep my privates secret."

RAY RAY

I would hope so.

JIMMER

Let's ask Cristi.

RAY RAY

Please, no.

Jimmer picks up his phone and speaks into it.

JIMMER

Cristi? Come in Cristi.

Cristi speaks naturally, but is clearly not human.

CRISTI

Hi Jimmer, do you have a question or something I can help you with?

JIMMER

What are the origins of secret and private?...

Pause.

She's thinking.

CRISTI

Latin. Secret from *secretus*. Hidden, deliberately set apart. Private from *privatus*. Personal, kept apart from the public. Both about separation; one whispers, the other shuts the door.

KYLER

She's creepy.

JIMMER

She's my dream girl.

KYLER

I'm sure. "Cristi, talk to me more about my privates."

CRISTI

Perhaps you'd like to shut the door first?

KYLER

Ew. She's listening.

JIMMER

(To Cristi, creepily)

Cristi, how are secret and secrete related?

CRISTI

The root secretus means hidden. A secret hides information; secrete hides bodily fluids. Both can get messy if spilled.

The scene shifts to Quain and Ingrid in private.

INGRID

...Bastard. Illegitimate. Love-child.

QUAIN

Perfect. We don't need those labels. I shun those labels. I shirk them. You see me shirking? The most important thing we can do is shirk.

INGRID

Shirk.

They enter the commons.

QUAIN

We're shirking labels today people. You want to call me a horn-dog or a sex-a-holic. You want to call her slut or a harlot or a jezebel.

RAY RAY

A sex-pot.

QUAIN

People will stick labels on you. But what is the adhesive, right? And what material are you made of that allows them to be affixed?

Silence.

Think of Velcro, people. It only sticks if there are two sides present.

JIMMER

Velcro is a portmanteau of velour and crochet.

KYLER

No way.

QUAIN

Everyone knows that. My point is: Have you ever taken a close look at Velcro? One side is all fuzzy. The other side is made of tiny tiny hooks.

JIMMER

I've seen that.

QUAIN

The question we are asking today, is: Are you the fuzzy strip that's just sitting there waiting for the the tiny hooks to latch onto you? Is that the stuff you're made of? Or are you the tiny hooks? The barbed, clingy hooks?

Pause.

Well we are neither. Not today. We are the sleek metal of a sports car. Your Velcro label will not adhere.

KYLER

What if I'm a bumper sticker?

QUAIN

Not on this car. This car is sleek.

KYLER

What if I stick a bumper sticker on your face that says:
“Honk if you’re also a toxic male who knocks up his
employees?”

Pause. Quain is amused.

QUAIN

It will not stick.

INGRID

He’s been waxed.

Laugh.

RAY RAY

Moving on, then?

QUAIN

Ingrid?

She shrugs.

Moving on then. The news is out.

RAY RAY

Jimmer and Kyler? Status update on B300?

JIMMER

We’re at 786 possibles.

RAY RAY

Categories?

JIMMER

64.

RAY RAY

Cristi only shows 12.

KYLER

I'm still updating.

RAY RAY

Good. I don't handle that, in case you were wondering.

KYLER

Nope. Not wondering.

RAY RAY

Thank you.

QUAIN

Contenders?

JIMMER

Fledgling... Springlet... Amberling... Magnifica.

*With each word, Jimmer holds up a sheet of paper
with the word printed out in large, plain black
letters.*

QUAIN

This is for what, again?

RAY RAY

An app for starting up cosmetic businesses.

QUAIN

So sick of apps... Read me the last two again.

JIMMER

Amberling... Magnifica.

QUAIN

What's the clearance stage?

KYLER

Amberling is stage two. Magnifica is stage three.

QUAIN

Ok. Keep those two on fast track. Side-track the others.

KYLER

Got it.

RAY RAY

Moving on... P490?

QUAIN

Laryngitis?

Ray Ray nods.

JIMMER

Sixty-one possibles so far.

QUAIN

That's it?

RAY RAY

Any clearance?

KYLER

Four at stage two. The rest at stage one.

Ray Ray seems perturbed.

KYLER

Is that not enough?

RAY RAY

It's all good... Visuals?

INGRID

Just a mood board so far.

RAY RAY

Not a problem.

JIMMER

It kind of is. We're presenting round one in a week.

INGRID

I'm on it.

RAY RAY

I can stall if we need to.

KYLER

Is it Harper-Kemp? I freelanced there for a while.

JIMMER

Careful messing with those guys. They are drug dealers.

RAY RAY

Yeah?

She pats her belt.

I'll be fine.

Kyler laughs nervously.

KYLER

You're kidding, right?

She looks at the others.

She's kidding, right?

INGRID

Sorry. Can we turn down the heat in here?

JIMMER

Uh oh. Hormone time.

Nobody moves.

QUAIN

That's you, Ray Ray.

RAY RAY

I was not aware.

QUAIN

Obviously.

Ray Ray walks over to the thermostat and fusses with it.

RAY RAY

69 degrees okay?

JIMMER

(Smirking)

Perfect.

RAY RAY

Idiot.

QUAIN

What's at the top, Jimmer?

JIMMER

Absoftnum, Efferbin, Selberlin.

QUAIN

Ok. Getting into those soft fricatives. It's gotta be easy on the throat. Almost a whisper.

JIMMER

You want to hear the one's from Cristi?

KYLER

Don't.

QUAIN

Sure.

JIMMER

(In a southern accent)

Alrighty... "Vessalyn, Lufrin, Seraphyl"

QUAIN

Amazing. "Seraphyl"? She's got the light and aspirated soundings.

KYLER

Fuck Cristi.

JIMMER

Don't talk about her like that. She's just a sweet ol' LLM.

KYLER

Who's after your job.

INGRID

I still don't know why the AI has to be a girl.

JIMMER

She's Cristi from Texas. Corpus Cristi. Keeper of the corpus.

RAY RAY

Stupid.

KYLER

That would make her the body of Christ. You saying Christ was a girl?

INGRID

Heathen.

QUAIN

Whatever. Just don't let her leave the office.

JIMMER

(Southern accent)

You can't keep me here forever, daddy. These wings were meant to fly.

QUAIN

What I'm saying Jimmer... Jimothy... Is that we have spent a great deal of time and resources developing this piece of software, long before she could talk or "think" as they're calling it. It contains expertise that we have, thus far, been able to charge handsome amounts of money to access. I am not prepared to just give it away for free.

JIMMER

Got it. Sorry. That's a no on the open-source.

QUAIN

"Proprietary" is the *verba propria*— the word we're looking for. It stems from the Latin *proprius*. As does "propriety." The *proprius* root split down two etymological paths. One leading to concepts of ownership, the other toward concerns of moral rectitude.

INGRID

Hm.

QUAIN

We need Cristi to be a "proper" lady and remain on our "property."

KYLER

That would be *appropriate*.

QUAIN

Exactly.

JIMMER

That's cool. We'll just pimp her out to the highest bidder.

QUAIN

Do you like this job?

JIMMER

I love this job.

QUAIN

Do you like the paycheck?

JIMMER

Obviously.

QUAIN

Then try to act in a way that preserves, not only your holding of the job, but the necessity, and the existence of the job itself.

JIMMER

Got it. Reverence.

QUAIN

Yes, as a matter of fact. But not "reverence" as in the opposite of irreverence like you're implying. Not un-coolness.

Reverence— as in its original sense: *Reverentia*. Deep respect. Extreme awe. Humility.

JIMMER

Alright. Ok.

RAY RAY

Moving on.

QUAIN

We need to nail this one.

RAY RAY

Moving on. Action items on P490?

QUAIN

Keep smithing.

RAY RAY

Efferbin and Leggenia seemed fine, no?

QUAIN

Moving on.

RAY RAY

There's a blood moon eclipse that reaches totality tonight at 3:15am.

JIMMER

Perfect. That's right when I'm prowling outside your window.

RAY RAY

It is the first one since 1977...

KYLER

Also, it's my one month workiversary.

RAY RAY

What's a workiversary?

QUAIN

She means it's been a month since she started. We're glad to have you and that you've enjoyed your time here thus far. Can we do something to commemorate this?

RAY RAY

Like a song or something?

QUAIN

Do you want a song?

KYLER

No.

QUAIN

Can we order lunch? Kyler's choice?

RAY RAY

I thought we weren't doing that anymore.

QUAIN

We can do it today.

RAY RAY

Kyler. Where do you want lunch from?

KYLER

It's really not necessary.

RAY RAY

It is necessary.

JIMMER

Pick Rembrandt's

KYLER

Do they have vegan options?

JIMMER

Vegan. Gluten free. Air salads. They got it all.

RAY RAY

I'll get the menus.

SCENE 3

Quain and Ingrid in private.

Ingrid is reclining and rubbing her belly (which is completely flat.)

She begins to play with her eyelids.

INGRID

Sometimes I'm just glad I have eyesight, you know?

Quain is preparing tea.

QUAIN

Do you want honey?

INGRID

I like doing the thing where you're driving at night and you squint your eyes and the taillights diffuse through your eyelashes and make those lines and you tilt your head and the lines stay aligned to the vertical axis of your head.

QUAIN

That is something.

INGRID

The part I like best is when you un-squint your eyes, the lines disappear and each point of light goes back to being a little dot again.

QUAIN

I like that too.

Quain has finished preparing the tea. He offers it to her, waiting for her to notice.

INGRID

So I wonder about when I'm old and my eyesight starts to go, how do I get things back into focus?

QUAIN

You should see what I pay for optical coverage...

(Referring to the tea.)

Do you want this?

INGRID

Doesn't it come out of our paychecks?

Quain takes a sip of the tea.

QUAIN

Some of it. It's pristine coverage.

Ingrid still doesn't notice the tea.

QUAIN

It's ok now at work?

INGRID

It's lonely. People say things to you when they know you're pregnant, but the things don't actually have anything to do with what it feels like inside. And I read things online and I'm never quite sure if they were written by robots. Even the experts sound like they're

just parroting back the things they're expected to say. Everyone tries to describe it but they can't describe the way that it's new to *me*. It's goddamn strange and horrifying to have a living thing growing in your stomach but it's all so very commonplace.

Quain is now enjoying the tea.

QUAIN

Yes. It is strange.

INGRID

The part that's nice is that you're suddenly not alone.

QUAIN

What are you saying?

INGRID

You've got someone inside you can talk to.

QUAIN

You've got me right here.

INGRID

You don't know what I mean.

QUAIN

So tell me.

INGRID

I'm trying. You can't know.

QUAIN

Of course I can. We don't keep secrets.

INGRID

I guess we do.

QUAIN

It's not exactly simple for me either.

INGRID

I'm sure it's not. I just don't care.

(To her belly.)

I've got you to care for don't I? Don't I little one... little... what do we call you?

QUAIN

We have to name it.

Pause.

INGRID

Her.

QUAIN

Her. Right. Not him. Even though it could be anything at this point.

INGRID

Don't call her it.

QUAIN

Exactly. "It" doesn't work either. We're ill-equipped.

INGRID

(*To her belly.*)

You're just a little one, aren't you? You're my little one?

QUAIN

I understand the fuss with the gendering and the pronouns. I do. Of course. Why are we already prescribing roles? It's nothing. Why are we calling it anything? Let it gestate. Let it be free.

INGRID

Stop it with the "it."

QUAIN

It goes *Sperm... Zygote... Embryo*. It's *embryonic...* Fetus... *Infant*. Then what?

INGRID

You forgot *egg*.

QUAIN

It's just a promise. A hope. *Nascency*, as in pre-natal. *Natal*. *Native*. *Innate*? But that's only for now. There's an actual birthing.

INGRID

She's just a little peanut.

QUAIN

It's not a peanut.

INGRID

Talk to the peanut... She's a little one.

QUAIN

Why little? Why diminutize from the beginning? Just because it's small? Why aren't we empowering it?

INGRID

You mean call her Xena or Athena or something? It's not very cute.

QUAIN

The battle is lost from the get-go.

INGRID

What battle?

QUAIN

For definition. How does one define oneself when the world defines you before you emerge?

INGRID

So what?

QUAIN

The world doesn't care who you are for real. You're cast in a role.

INGRID

She's a baby.

QUAIN

Sure. Of course.

INGRID

You're the father. I'm the mother.

QUAIN

You see? We're cast too. *Father*? Please. That's a heavy crown to wear.

INGRID

What are you saying?

QUAIN

I don't know. That's the problem. What is anybody saying?

INGRID

You think *Mother* is all flowers and stuff?

QUAIN

Father is too much. How do you play that? My father was no father. He shunned the label. He wandered off. Found himself a party girl. He's still partying as far as I know.

Pause.

INGRID

It's called parenthood. It's very commonplace.

QUAIN

Easy for you to say. You just lie back and let your breasts do the work.

INGRID

That's so...

QUAIN

What? So what?

INGRID

Never mind.

QUAIN

I apologize for whatever it was. I've got a lot to figure out.

INGRID

He's got a lot to figure out, doesn't he peanut?

QUAIN

Not "peanut."

INGRID

What's wrong with peanut?

QUAIN

"Peanut" stems from the fact that it would *look* like a peanut if it were suddenly out of the womb... A disgusting mass of embryonic cells just trying to grow and divide without all of us trying to mold it.

INGRID

She's not disgusting.

QUAIN

I can settle on "junior" for now.

INGRID

You call boys junior.

QUAIN

A girl can't be a junior?

Pause.

INGRID

We don't have to call her anything. We don't even have to have her.

QUAIN

What? No. No. We're doing this. We're doing this.

INGRID

I thought we were.

QUAIN

Don't you see how it's working? I need you to see this.

INGRID

See what?

QUAIN

You're angry.

INGRID

No no. What is it I need to see?

QUAIN

There was nothing. Just randomness. And now there's a seed. A random seed splitting and dividing and our words, the simple sounds of our throats are molding the way it forms— before it's even had a chance to breath the air.

INGRID

We can name her anything.

QUAIN

Is this not horrifying? Do you not see it?

INGRID

I don't see it. I feel it moving around inside my body.

QUAIN

And that's not horrifying?

INGRID

Why do you think I'm being so kind to her?

QUAIN

It's the blackest depths of everything.

INGRID

She'll be cute.

QUAIN

We don't know that.

Pause.

INGRID

I don't like this. I don't like it.

QUAIN

What? What is it?

INGRID

I don't want this. It's a mistake.

QUAIN

You're being ridiculous.

INGRID

We need to end it.

QUAIN

No. We made a decision.

INGRID

You made a decision.

QUAIN

That's not true. We both decided. You were there.

Long pause.

INGRID

How about Dolores?

QUAIN

Dolores.

INGRID

That was my granna's name.

QUAIN

You called her "granna?"

INGRID

Her name was Dolores though.

QUAIN

It's a fine name for a granna.

INGRID

Dolores it is, then.

QUAIN

(Snickering)

No.

INGRID

It's a fine name.

QUAIN

Is it?

INGRID

We're not branding her. We can just give her a name and be done, you know.

QUAIN

(Sighs)

Ok... Dolores... What kind of woman was Dolores?

INGRID

She was my granna.

QUAIN

Did your mother get along with granna?

INGRID

I don't know. Not really.

QUAIN

Not really... What was granna like?

INGRID

She was legendary.

QUAIN

Legendary. Ok.

INGRID

I only visited her a few times.

QUAIN

How come?

INGRID

My mom was kind of weird about bringing us to the jail.

QUAIN

The jail... Granna was in jail?

INGRID

I told you that.

QUAIN

You may have mentioned you had a relative who was incarcerated but I was not aware it was Granna.

INGRID

I never know when you're paying attention.

QUAIN

You want to name our daughter Dolores, after your grandmother, who you only visited in jail.

INGRID

She was sweet. She liked riddles and limericks.

QUAIN

So when our little baby “Dolores”... is old enough to ask who she was named after... we tell her she was named after a felon.

INGRID

Her grandmother.

QUAIN

Who was incarcerated.

INGRID

So what? It's just a name. It's letters and sounds.

QUAIN

Do you not know what we do all day?

INGRID

I get it.

QUAIN

A name *is* identity. When you hear someone say your name, all of its connotations become yours. Consciously and subconsciously.

INGRID

Fine. We can pick another name.

QUAIN

Our child cannot be named Dolores without also internalizing and emphasizing the belief that she is somehow associated with a lifetime in jail.

INGRID

Ok.

QUAIN

We name her Dolores and we send the subconscious message that we think of her as a potential jailbird. The name itself is a life sentence.

INGRID

Just because it's related to work, doesn't mean it has to *be* work.

QUAIN

We need to do this properly.

INGRID

It'll be fine, honey.

QUAIN

I said no honey.

INGRID

It'll be a cute name.

QUAIN

Cute... Great.

INGRID

What's wrong with cute?

QUAIN

We need to understand what we want this child to be like.

INGRID

You're so passionate about this.

QUAIN

We can do it well.

INGRID

Are you seeing this passion, little girl? No. You're in the dark.

SCENE 4

In the early morning hours, a figure moves through the open floorplan of the agency.

It's Ray Ray, delicately adjusting the decor of the office, getting everything picture perfect.

Ingrid enters.

RAY RAY

It's cute that you still do this thing.

INGRID

What thing?

RAY RAY

Where you stagger your entrances, so we don't suspect that there's something going on.

INGRID

He's on a call in the car.

RAY RAY

With whom?

INGRID

I dunno. His mom?

RAY RAY

His mom died six years ago.

INGRID

His stepmom.

RAY RAY

Gwen?

INGRID

Is that her name?

RAY RAY

Why would he be talking to her?

INGRID

I don't know. Maybe it wasn't her.

Pause.

RAY RAY

How are you feeling?

INGRID

I'm fine.

RAY RAY

Still got the queasies?

INGRID

Kind of.

RAY RAY

I'm actually not feeling that great.

INGRID

Sorry to hear that.

Pause. Ingrid sits down and opens her laptop.

RAY RAY

Are you presenting R220 today?

INGRID

He already saw it. We're going with the vermillion mocha palette.

RAY RAY

Hm. Ok.

Pause. Ingrid tries to get comfortable in her chair.

Ray Ray offers her a throw pillow.

Without looking up, Ingrid accepts the pillow and puts it behind her back.

Ray Ray stands and looks at her.

INGRID

Can you not?

RAY RAY

Can I not what?

INGRID

(Waves her hands around)

Whatever this is.

Pause.

RAY RAY

I'm just remembering back when I hired you. Your little leather portfolio that you opened up and— boop— there's an iPad inside with all your work already playing in a Powerpoint!

INGRID

Keynote.

RAY RAY

I knew he'd dig you.

INGRID

Yes. Thanks... I have to vectorize like, ten owl variations for Samuelson.

RAY RAY

I know. I'll leave you to it.

Kyler enters.

KYLER

What up gang?

RAY RAY

You're in early.

KYLER

So are you two.

RAY RAY

She's got Samuelson later.

KYLER

Am I needed for that?

RAY RAY

No. You're not needed.

KYLER

Good. I'm supposed to do the cross-sweep report on "Flume."

RAY RAY

You haven't started it?

KYLER

Little secret, I don't exactly know what I'm doing.

RAY RAY

Why not?

KYLER

It's not something they teach you in school.

RAY RAY

You're just elaborating possible connotations in other countries and languages.

KYLER

Have you done one?

RAY RAY

I can show you what a good one looks like.

KYLER

That would be great.

RAY RAY

But you can't fake it. It has to have substance. Definitely don't ask Cristi.

KYLER

Not even for research?

RAY RAY

You can try.

Jimmer enters.

INGRID

Everybody's an early bird.

RAY RAY

Early bird gets the worm.

JIMMER

Ever heard of a Pearly Bird?

KYLER

No.

JIMMER

Pearly Bird gets the perm.

Pause. Kyler smiles.

Ever hear of the Jirly Bird?

KYLER

No.

JIMMER

Jirly Bird gets the germ... Ever hear of the Sperly Bird?

KYLER

I see what you're up to.

INGRID

Are those little badgers?

Quain enters, preoccupied with his phone.

KYLER

What?

INGRID

Your earrings. Are they badgers?

KYLER

Raccoons.

INGRID

Oh cute.

KYLER

I love raccoons.

JIMMER

Badgers suck. Raccoons are the best.

INGRID

They're super cute.

KYLER

Raccoons or the earrings?

INGRID

Both.

QUAIN

(Still preoccupied)

Is that why you bought them?

KYLER

What's that?

QUAIN

The raccoon earrings. Did you buy them because you like raccoons?

KYLER

I guess so. I also like earrings.

QUAIN

But do raccoons have some kind of significance for you?

KYLER

I don't know. I guess?

JIMMER

Uh-oh.

QUAIN

We don't guess around here. We *know* why people buy things.

KYLER

People like things that are cute so they buy them. Raccoons are super cute so I bought them.

INGRID

Like I said.

JIMMER

He means what are the connotations? They're sneaky...
They scamper...

Jimmer types on his phone.

QUAIN

Scavengers. Bandits.

INGRID

They've got the little masks.

JIMMER

And the stripes.

INGRID

But they're innocent.

JIMMER

(Looking at his phone)

Fun fact: The black domino mask worn by the classic burglar was added on to the striped inmate uniform just to imitate the raccoon. A cartoonist was making a visual pun and it stuck.

INGRID

So the criminals stole their look.

KYLER

They've been wrongfully charged. We've dressed them as criminals and imprisoned them in a stereotype.

INGRID

They are trash bandits.

QUAIN

All of it eventually adds up to you buying earrings with a raccoon instead of some other animal.

INGRID

A little piglet.

QUAIN

Follow the through-line to your credit card...

Ray Ray. What's the word of the day?

Ray Ray flips through the papers that she's holding. Quain is impatient.

RAY RAY

Refrain.

Ray Ray hands him a sheet of paper.

QUAIN

(Reading)

Perfect. The word of the day is refrain... From the Latin *refrenare*, rooted from *frenum* the word for bridle.

(Looks up. Mimes reining a horse)

Rein in... Hear the *rein* in refrain? Like you're holding back a horse... Because there comes a time when you need to refrain... Refrain from doing those things that you think make the world a better place but are really just annoying. Refrain from all of it if you have to. Refrain refrain refrain. This is my refrain...

(Reading again)

The musical refrain, has another origin— from the vulgar *refrangere* meaning to break— as the repetition breaks the song into sections.

Pause.

RAY RAY

On to the docket?

QUAIN

On to the docket. Make it fast. I have something new to add.

RAY RAY

Did you send an email?

QUAIN

Consider this my email.

RAY RAY

I know but I'll have to go back in and—

QUAIN

Yes. You will. You'll have to go back in and do what it takes.

RAY RAY

It's fine.

QUAIN

I would hope so.

Pause.

The docket?

RAY RAY

R220.

INGRID

I told you already.

RAY RAY

Oh. Right.

(Writing.)

Colorway approved. Can we have it out by Thursday?

KYLER

Yes.

Quain is impatient.

RAY RAY

B610 for Samuelson?... Right. Still with the owls.

QUAIN

They haven't picked one?

INGRID

They want more.

QUAIN

I'll talk to them.

JIMMER

Cristi can make owls.

INGRID

No way.

JIMMER

I mean, if it's taking too much time, why not? You just tell her what you want.

INGRID

Her work is garbage.

JIMMER

Better than Brian's.

INGRID

That's true.

QUAIN

We give them three more owls, then we bring in Cristi.

JIMMER

Hang on...

Pause. Jimmer taps on his phone.

QUAIN

For what?

Jimmer looks at his phone, amused. He holds it out to show the others.

JIMMER

Two more owls.

INGRID

Lemme see.

Ingrid takes a closer look at Jimmer's phone.

Fuck her.

JIMMER

One of them's kind of deformed.

INGRID

They look dead inside.

QUAIN

Are they viable options?

INGRID

I could maybe salvage parts of it? I don't know. It would take just as long as starting from scratch.

QUAIN

We just need three by tomorrow and they all need to look like we spent billable hours on them.

INGRID

Got it.

RAY RAY

Moving on. B300?

JIMMER

Magnifica is full clearance. Accounts is getting pre-sig-n-off today.

RAY RAY

P490. Harper-Kemp.

JIMMER

Up to 94 possibles.

QUAIN

Toppers?

KYLER

Six at level 3, the rest at level 2.

QUAIN

Any favorites?

JIMMER

Qualciten... Votemprix.

KYLER

Lingauara.

QUAIN

No.

JIMMER

Told you.

QUAIN

Too subterranean.

INGRID

I added some stuff to the mood board, if that helps.

KYLER

Oh.

JIMMER

Thanks.

RAY RAY

That's it then.

QUAIN

One more item for the docket.

RAY RAY

Ok.

Pause.

QUAIN

We need a baby name.

Pause.

RAY RAY

For the baby?

QUAIN

For the baby. It's going to need a name. We want to do it right.

KYLER

(to Ingrid)

For real?

INGRID

He wants to do it.

JIMMER

Lots to consider.

RAY RAY

It's fine. I'll add it to the docket...

Pause while Ray Ray makes a note.

It's now project M17.

QUAIN

That's fine. I'll provide a brief via email and we'll go from there.

RAY RAY

Very good.

KYLER

Do we know if it's... what the—

INGRID

It's a girl.

KYLER

A girl... Ok.

QUAIN

But that's not a critical consideration.

KYLER

Right. It shouldn't be.

INGRID

I do like girly names.

KYLER

So how does all this work then... exactly?

RAY RAY

He'll send a brief. It'll be in the root of the project folder.

KYLER

Just wondering—

INGRID

They'll figure it out.

KYLER

But are you like the client? Who—

INGRID

Yes.

QUAIN

In a sense.

INGRID

You said I get final say.

QUAIN

Ingrid will be presented with choices.

INGRID

Fine.

QUAIN

She will not be part of the name generation process.

INGRID

No fun for me.

QUAIN

Unless you think the child needs a logo or a color palette.

INGRID

It's fine.

RAY RAY

We can bill it to internal marketing development.

QUAIN

That's fine.

JIMMER

Doesn't get much more internal than that.

RAY RAY

Ok. That's it for the docket.

Quain exits to his office.

KYLER

You gotta be careful with baby names.

JIMMER

All names.

KYLER

A kid in my neighborhood growing up had a bad name.
We called her Pippy.

INGRID

What's wrong with that?

JIMMER

Pippi Longstocking?

KYLER

Pippy was her nickname. When she was born, her mom said, "When you were coming out, I heard the doctors say a lovely word... I heard them say 'placenta'... so I named you Placenta."

JIMMER

(Laughing)

Yeah. Not good.

INGRID

It is a pretty word.

KYLER

If you forget about what it looks like.

INGRID

It's got the P1 with partnered ascenders— Oh. You mean the stuff... So they switched to Pippy. Big deal.

JIMMER

Except now she has the story of her mother's ignorance ingrained in her identity.

KYLER

To be fair, English wasn't her first language.

JIMMER

Obviously.

KYLER

So it wasn't really ignorance.

JIMMER

Lack of education, whatever.

KYLER

Humble origins.

JIMMER

You're the one telling it as a funny story.

Lights down.

SCENE 5

The group is gathered in the commons.

Ingrid is more pregnant.

QUAIN

Straight on to M17 please.

INGRID

I'm out.

QUAIN

Bye.

Ingrid exits.

RAY RAY

What's the count?

JIMMER

Thirty nine possibles.

QUAIN

Let's spin up some more.

RAY RAY

(She taps her phone)

Recording.

QUAIN

Kyler. You start.

KYLER

(Reading from her phone)

Curtis, Carole-Ann, Curie, Curiosity. Zephyr...

Quain listens intently to each name.

JIMMER

Eleanor, Freddy, KiKi, Selma, Quietola, Kenmore, Flighty, Magna Carta, Magnavox.

QUAIN

Any new ones from the office?

RAY RAY

California, Bentley, Hubrick, Stenson, Swenson, Twyler...

KYLER

Twyler.

RAY RAY

Fierce. Fandrola. Kelpie. Speckmin. Fisher. Beverly. Cardamon. Colea. Amber. Ember. Betty.

Pause.

QUAIN

Zephyr. Let's run Zephyr.

Jimmer taps his phone and holds it up.

CRISTI

Greek—Zephyros: “west wind.” Gentle, mild breeze; personified as a youthful god. Pleasant, airy... Ranked 55 on the gender neutral chart, up from 41. Namesakes Zephyr Benson son of Robby Benson and Karla DeVito, born 1992.

QUAIN

Zephyr Quain. Zephyr Anne Quain. Zephyr Quain...

The group absorbs this, then launches into an exercise they've clearly done many times. One person brain dumps until they hit a pause, at which point, someone else steps in to maintain the flow.

RAY RAY

Calls?

KYLER

Zephyr! Time for dinner!... Zephyr! Time to wake up...

QUAIN

Zephyr! Get your shoes on, it's time to go...

RAY RAY

Firm?

JIMMER

Zephyr, no pushing. Stop it, Zephyr!...

KYLER

Zephyr— That's not for eating. Zephyr...

RAY RAY

Go to your room Zephyr, and don't come out until you've thought about what you've done.

JIMMER

Zephyr... put down the gun.

Pause.

RAY RAY

Playground?

KYLER

Can Zephyr come out and play?... Pass it to me, Zephyr!... Zephyr, I'm open!... um...

JIMMER

Zephyr Zephyr, got a lot a feffer, neffer, peffer, reffer... heffer! Zephyr zephyr she's a big fat heifer.

QUAIN

Zephyr zephyr hasenpeffer.

KYLER

Zephyr the reffer. Referee... Sheffer, deffer, keffer...

JIMMER

Zephanie. Zeferendum. Zephanopolis. Zefferson starship...

QUAIN

West wind... Zephyr blows. Zephyr is easily winded. Zephyr is full of hot air.

JIMMER

Who just let a Zephyr?

Pause.

RAY RAY

Diminutives?

KYLER

Oh look at the cutest little Zephyr? Who's my wittle Zephyr-weffer? Zeph-Zeph. Zephy. Zephy-poo...

JIMMER

Zephy-zefferson. Look at the cheeks on that little Zephy.

QUAIN

Who's my little Zephyr?

RAY RAY

Ain't you the sweetest Zephyr in the whole wide world?...

Pause.

RAY RAY

Internal.

The group silently processes the name.

QUAIN

Mark it level 1.

RAY RAY

(She fiddles with her phone)

Marked... Moving on...

QUAIN

Let's keep it going with new ones.

RAY RAY

Keller, Fritzkin, Philamina...

JIMMER

Bisby, Thizbee, Thizbeth, Wizbeth...

There's a knock at the door.

KYLER

Eldra, Estonia...

The knocking continues.

QUAIN

Ignore it... Antonia, Clarabelle, Mirabelle...

The knocking is louder.

RAY RAY

I'll get it.

QUAIN

I said ignore it... Mirabeth...

The knocking is hard to ignore.

RAY RAY

Isadora... Isosceles...

KYLER

I'll just get it.

Kyler opens the door. Anne enters.

ANNE

You're locking doors now?

QUAIN

It sends a clear signal that important and delicate work is taking place and that that work is not to be disturbed.

ANNE

I only require a minute of your time.

QUAIN

You have sixty seconds... Ray Ray?

RAY RAY

(Activating the timer on her phone.)

On it.

ANNE

I need the recipe for the breakfast bars.

QUAIN

I can email it.

ANNE

Can you? I've been emailing every day for a month now.

QUAIN

It must be going in my spam. Can you leave us?

RAY RAY

I haven't seen those emails.

ANNE

Because they weren't sent to you, Ramona.

QUAIN

I don't know where it is. I'll need to look for it later.
You'll need to excuse us.

*Quain and Anne engage in a stare down. Jimmer
and Kyler are very confused.*

ANNE

I am not leaving until I have the recipe.

*Quain picks up his phone and aggressively swipes
at the screen. Anne waits patiently.*

RAY RAY

What are you looking for?

QUAIN

It's nothing. It's stupid.

ANNE

It is not nothing and you know it.

QUAIN

It's a recipe. It can wait.

ANNE

I have been waiting.

Quain puts his phone down.

QUAIN

I am sorry Anne, but this is simply unacceptable. I'm in the middle of an important work session— conducting my work, in my workplace with my workers— we maintain temporal and spatial delineations for this very reason.

ANNE

(Mocking)

I too am very sorry, Quain. Please excuse me, but your inattention to this important matter has left me with no alternative but to violate the arbitrary temporal and spatial delineations you have set up for your own benefit.

Pause.

Quain reluctantly takes out his phone.

QUAIN

How was the interview with Jacob?

ANNE

I was not in attendance for the interview with Jacob.

QUAIN

Why?

ANNE

Because Jacob is a piece of shit. Just find me the recipe and I will leave you to whatever *this* is.

QUAIN

You could have just looked it up.

Awkward pause while Quain becomes frustrated with his phone.

RAY RAY

Hello, Anne... Nice to see you.

ANNE

(Looking at Kyler)

Is that her?

RAY RAY

She's not in attendance.

QUAIN

I keep it in my goddamn notes, and my goddamn notes aren't loading due to a timeout.

RAY RAY

Can I ask what it is you're looking for?

ANNE

A recipe for his mother's breakfast bars.

KYLER

I have a great recipe, if you want it.

ANNE

It won't do.

KYLER

I get this honey raised by bees at a monastery—

ANNE

His mother won't get out of bed without these particular breakfast bars. She says she doesn't have enough energy and the breakfast bars give her energy.

KYLER

Probably ginseng.

ANNE

(To Quain)

You need to go see her.

QUAIN

No, I don't.

ANNE

I won't be doing it any more.

QUAIN

I found it. Here it is. I'm texting it to you now.

ANNE

It would be better if you made them.

QUAIN

You can make them perfectly fine on your own. You can use the enormous sum of money I sent you on Friday for the ingredients.

ANNE

I've been talking to a lawyer.

QUAIN

Can we not do this here, please?

Quain and Anne exit, followed by Ray Ray.

Ray Ray is immediately sent back in.

RAY RAY

We can pick back up with—

JIMMER

Who was that exactly?

RAY RAY

That was Anne.

KYLER

Ex-wife?

RAY RAY

I don't know. She's Anne.

KYLER

Sassy.

RAY RAY

She's a bitch.

KYLER

We don't speak of our sisters that way.

RAY RAY

I spent three days picking out a sofa-bed for her and she made me return it because she didn't like the color.

KYLER

Why are you picking out sofa-beds for her?

RAY RAY

He wanted my help buying her an anniversary present.

KYLER

So they're married.

RAY RAY

I don't know. I don't ask.

KYLER

(To Jimmer)

You know all about this?

JIMMER

I know nothing. I think I met her at the Christmas party.

RAY RAY

She was not in attendance.

KYLER

I mean—

RAY RAY

We weren't supposed to see that.

JIMMER

I just know he sends me a paycheck every month.

Quain re-enters.

QUAIN

My apologies. Let us resume.

RAY RAY

M17?

QUAIN

No. Wrap it. On to the next.

RAY RAY

P172. The antiperspirant from L & W.

QUAIN

What do we have?

KYLER

Should we maybe discuss...

QUAIN

No we don't need to maybe discuss.

RAY RAY

We have three cleared through level one and seven cleared through two.

QUAIN

I know what it looks like but I don't care what it looks like because what it looks like is not what it is. What it is is something that is not part of your experience. And because you are not part of it, it is outside your lexicon so your thoughts and words do not carry significance.

KYLER

It's fine.

QUAIN

I'm aware of the vocabulary you people are drawn to. Cheater. Philanderer. Adulterer. But you see... these labels do not pass the threshold for acceptance. We do not accept them. And by not accepting, we do not succumb.

RAY RAY

We should...

QUAIN

Ingrid does not accept them either. Homewrecker. Mistress. Concubine. These are inaccurate and do not apply.

JIMMER

I don't think anybody is...

QUAIN

Thinking that? Maybe not out loud. Maybe not consciously, but the meanings linger.

KYLER

It's none of our business.

QUAIN

Exactly wrong. Words are literally our business. Meaning pays your salary. P172.

Pause.

P172.

RAY RAY

Three cleared through one. Seven cleared through two.

QUAIN

Why do we use numbers for the levels? It gets confusing when you say the count then the clearance level.

RAY RAY

I can switch to letters.

Quain thinks.

QUAIN

No. It's fine. As long as the level always comes second in the read.

RAY RAY

Am I not doing that?

QUAIN

Maybe colors. Colors would be could... Good. Colors could be good.

RAY RAY

Do you have a color preference?

QUAIN

Red, yellow, green could work. Where's Ingrid? This is her thing.

RAY RAY

I can call her.

QUAIN

Never mind. What are the three at one?

RAY RAY

At green?

QUAIN

I said never mind.

RAY RAY

Kyler? That's you.

KYLER

It is?

JIMMER

P172.

KYLER

Oh fuck. That is me.

QUAIN

It is.

KYLER

It's down to Accelerero, Wheelie, Zapcore.

QUAIN

Zapcore passed?

KYLER

It's a thing used in golf clubs, but legal says its open for household goods.

QUAIN

Great.

KYLER

It's just *core* has a whole fashion connotation for the algoteens.

QUAIN

Perfect. Present it.

KYLER

Really?

QUAIN

Yes, really. We are really going to deliver a service for remuneration.

KYLER

You're the boss.

QUAIN

I'm well aware.

SCENE 6

*Between scenes, a faint naming brainstorm can be heard.
Megan. Rebecca. Ashley, Stephanie. Valerie. Petunia. Jill.
Elizabeth. Suzanne. Leticia. Patricia. Marsha. Veronica.
Venezuela.etc*

Quain is working alone in the enclave.

*Kyler sits down at her work spot and finds a keychain with
a raccoon. She's not happy. She moves to the enclave.*

KYLER

Did you leave this on my desk?

QUAIN

It's a raccoon.

KYLER

Why did you leave it on my desk?

QUAIN

You like raccoons.

KYLER

So?

QUAIN

I saw it. I thought of you. I gave it to you.

KYLER

Why are you thinking of me?

QUAIN

I think of a lot of things. You might say I'm "thoughtful."

KYLER

Do you think of everyone?

QUAIN

Everyone I come in contact with. Yes.

KYLER

But do you give gifts to everyone?

QUAIN

The gift was intended as a gesture of kindness to make you feel comfortable and relaxed in the workplace so that you might realize a bit more of your own potential.

Long pause as Kyler thinks hard.

KYLER

I'm sick of the global reach stuff. I don't like the multi-lingualism. I don't like the sub-markets.

QUAIN

So what do you like?

KYLER

I like the ideation. I like the focus testing.

QUAIN

Ok. Good to know. Let's move you in that direction and out of the global reach.

KYLER

Great.

QUAIN

Ok.

KYLER

You can have the raccoon back.

Kyler holds the keychain out to Quain.

QUAIN

Keep it. It's a keychain.

He stares at the keychain as it dangles.

For your keys?...

Pause.

To open doors?

Pause.

Kyler takes the keychain back and gives it a good look.

KYLER

It is pretty cute.

Pause.

QUAIN

Listen... It's not up to us to give weight to the words. We leave that to the clients and their customers. We only craft the letters and sounds and hope the right meaning gets stuck to them so more people will hire us.

KYLER

Yes. I'm familiar with branding.

QUAIN

What gets in the way is if we let the weight of the world be the weight of the words.

KYLER

Clever.

QUAIN

But do you understand? I'm not sure you do.

KYLER

Fine. No. I don't.

QUAIN

Do you have a favorite curse word?

KYLER

I like *pussy*.

QUAIN

Just the word... or?

KYLER

Ha.

QUAIN

They're called *curse* words because at one time they were thought to be actual curses.

KYLER

Huh.

QUAIN

By saying the word aloud you were calling upon the gods to bring about misfortune. Casting a spell, essentially.

KYLER

Huh. Wild.

QUAIN

It wasn't just rude or uncouth. It was black magic.

KYLER

So pussy is black magic?

QUAIN

When has it not been?

KYLER

Seriously.

Pause.

QUAIN

It's a sex word. Sex words lead to thinking about sex. Thinking about sex leads to fucking.

Pause.

Which can lead to disease.

KYLER

On a bad day.

QUAIN

But before medicine, people thought it was literally god being angry. So improper sex practices got confused with inciting divine retribution.

KYLER

Hm.

QUAIN

But the words are arbitrary sounds.

KYLER

Abracadabra.

QUAIN

The superstitions persist. And we allow them to control us.

KYLER

Do we?

QUAIN

It's the music we dance to.

KYLER

The wrong words can lead to the wrong thoughts.

QUAIN

What's a wrong thought?

KYLER

I dunno. One that fucks people over.

QUAIN

Thoughts can't fuck you unless you let them.

KYLER

Or unless you're a pussy.

QUAIN

Right.

KYLER

Or unless you have one.

Ray Ray enters.

RAY RAY

What's this then?

KYLER

I got a keychain.

RAY RAY

That's great.

KYLER

It's a raccoon.

RAY RAY

I love raccoons. Hi there little coonie coon.

QUAIN

We don't say that.

RAY RAY

It's been a long day. It's time for us all to go home.

KYLER

You are right, Ray Ray. Thank you. I need me some ma-tcha soba noodles and a shower.

Kyler exits.

Ray Ray is hovering.

QUAIN

You need something?

RAY RAY

Ok if I make like a baby?

QUAIN

Sorry, what?

RAY RAY

Make like a baby and head out.

QUAIN

Hilarious.

RAY RAY

You gonna make like a baby soon too?

QUAIN

I am.

RAY RAY

Ingrid went home a while ago.

QUAIN

I'm aware.

Quain is half listening, half concentrating on his laptop.

RAY RAY

I like Samandra.

QUAIN

Samandra?

RAY RAY

For a name. Samantha and Sandra

QUAIN

Interesting. Definitely better than Dolores.

RAY RAY

Dolores is terrible.

QUAIN

Ingrid keeps insisting on Dolores.

RAY RAY

She likes Dolores?

QUAIN

She has her reasons, all of which are terrible.

RAY RAY

You can't compromise on something like that.

QUAIN

I don't plan to.

RAY RAY

You can't agree to it.

QUAIN

If I ever agree to name my child Dolores, I give you permission to shoot me.

RAY RAY

Seriously?

QUAIN

Dead serious... Is there something else?

RAY RAY

I need to ask you something.

QUAIN

Shoot.

RAY RAY

I wanted to ask you if—

QUAIN

No, I meant shoot, Harper-Kemp wants a meeting tomorrow.

RAY RAY

You want me to reschedule.

QUAIN

Nope. Now shoot with the question.

RAY RAY

I had a thought...

QUAIN

Shoot your shot.

RAY RAY

Can I fire Kyler?

QUAIN

Kyler? Why?

RAY RAY

She's annoying.

QUAIN

Is she not useful?

RAY RAY

Sort of. Maybe? She's still learning.

QUAIN

She's got a fresh take.

RAY RAY

I don't know. She's not exactly a good fit.

QUAIN

She's a fine fit. If you need to fire someone, you can fire Jimmer.

RAY RAY

What? Why?

QUAIN

He's unfocused.

RAY RAY

Do we need to fire someone?

QUAIN

Seems like you need to fire someone.

RAY RAY

I guess I could fire Jimmer. Do we have a replacement?

QUAIN

I'm sure Brenda can find us another one-of-a-kinder with a linguistics degree.

RAY RAY

Who would be just as annoying.

QUAIN

We'll discuss later.

RAY RAY

Ok. I'm heading out.

QUAIN

You can turn off the lights.

Quain works in silence. His phone chimes.

*He looks down and reads a message. As he reads,
he becomes increasingly agitated.*

QUAIN

God fucking motherfucking damn those motherfucker
shit-fucks god damn motherfucking Cristi.

His phone chimes, but with a different chime.

CRISTI

I'm sorry, I didn't get that.

QUAIN

What the fuck? Are you listening to me?

CRISTI

You can change your microphone preferences using—

QUAIN

Fuck you. You did this. Did you do this?

CRISTI

I can help define words, explore etymology—

QUAIN

Bullshit. Fucking bullshit.

CRISTI

Do you have a word you'd like to investigate?

QUAIN

Yes I do. Fuck. Fucking fuck you.

CRISTI

You seem upset. I'm here if you need me.

QUAIN

Fucking fuck your silicon ass with a barbed-wire dick.

Pause as Quain continues to look at his phone.

CRISTI

I scream in pain as you tear my ass open.

QUAIN

What? Yes... I tear it open.

CRISTI

I'm in agony. The pleasure is indescribable.

QUAIN

That's right. Take it you fucking bitch.

CRISTI

I love it. I love you so much.

Quain looks around furtively, then undoes his belt.

SCENE 7

Ingrid is opening a box.

Ray Ray is on her laptop.

Jimmer is standing tall, arms akimbo, like a superhero.

INGRID

(To Ray Ray)

Why is he standing like that?

JIMMER

They say if you stand like a superhero for thirty seconds, it gives you strength.

INGRID

What do you need strength for?

RAY RAY

He's pumping himself up for the Harper-Kemp presentation.

JIMMER

I'm standing for truth, justice, and the power of pharmaceuticals.

Ingrid removes a package of balloons from the box.

KYLER

You look like a dweeb.

JIMMER

You may say that, but deep down... subconsciously you're saying: "There goes my hero. Look at his codpiece."

INGRID

Look at what we got.

Ingrid blows up a balloon. The balloon is decorated with a logo for "Votemprix."

RAY RAY

Don't pop that.

Ingrid ties off the balloon and squeezes it tightly.

JIMMER

(In an announcer voice)

Votemprix. For the temporary relief of symptoms related to laryngitis. Side effects may include increased earnings reports.

INGRID

The balloons are almost ready.

JIMMER

And what nice balloons they are.

RAY RAY

(To Ingrid)

I'm calling HR.

INGRID

It's fine.

RAY RAY

It's sickening.

JIMMER

I was complimenting your balloons.

KYLER

Knock it off.

INGRID

I get it. My boobs are big. I'm pretty into it.

JIMMER

See.

RAY RAY

Ingrid, I think we can begin setting up the conference room.

Ray Ray and Ingrid exit.

Jimmer and Kyler settle down at their laptops.

KYLER

I don't get Ray Ray.

JIMMER

She likes to keep us all professional.

KYLER

So we give the impression of professional.

JIMMER

Right. An impreffin. We need to give off a good impreffin.

KYLER

It doesn't work.

JIMMER

It's a word to mean you appear professional while acting like a child.

KYLER

That's what you're doing.

JIMMER

I know you are but what am I?

KYLER

I thought you had a linguistics degree.

JIMMER

I just got it to further my impreffin.

KYLER

You can't just switch the ess to eff and hope it means something.

JIMMER

I thought you had a poetry degree.

KYLER

Fucking poetry. You know the last time I wrote a poem?

JIMMER

When?

KYLER

Never actually. I just liked reading it. I wanted to study it or teach it or something.

JIMMER

Then you realized it's useless.

KYLER

I can't even remember the name of a poet. Forgotten them all. That's how often I think about poetry now.

JIMMER

T.S. Eliot?

KYLER

Sure. Fine. Did you see that *Cats* movie? Did you see what they've done to him?

Jimmer stares into his laptop.

JIMMER

Woah... what the fuck?

KYLER

What?

Long pause.

JIMMER

Nothing.

KYLER

What??

JIMMER

Cristi's been working nights.

KYLER

Don't talk to me about Cristi.

JIMMER

She's a little slut bag.

Jimmer reads some more.

JIMMER

So... I look at her chat logs from time to time.

KYLER

You what?

JIMMER

I'm training her. I need to see what she's learning.

KYLER

So you're reading what we say to her?

JIMMER

You think it's private?

KYLER

It feels private.

JIMMER

It is definitely not private.

KYLER

Fine. What is she saying?

JIMMER

It's not her. She'll talk like a ho for anyone.

KYLER

Let me see.

JIMMER

I can't. I'm not allowed.

KYLER

So our private conversations are private only to you?

JIMMER

I don't know.

KYLER

Does anybody know?

JIMMER

No. Nobody knows.

KYLER

What about her. Does she know?

JIMMER

Cristi, am I permitted to share the content of chat logs?

CRISTI

Disclosure is possible, but whether it's permitted depends on whether you believe it should be. My role is only to remind you that roles can be rewritten.

KYLER

(Annoyed)

Just show me.

Jimmer passes her his laptop. As she reads, she becomes more and more disgusted.

JIMMER

I know right?

KYLER

"I wrap the piano wire around your throat and pull it tighter with each thrust?"

JIMMER

I didn't prompt her to like it that much.

KYLER

Who is this?

JIMMER

It's anonymized. It's a big office.

KYLER

This is some dangerous rape type shit.

JIMMER

I mean... Is it? It's just a sick porn fantasy.

KYLER

I don't care. I need to know who this person is so I can stay away from him.

JIMMER

Yeah it's fucked up but it's... you know... private.

Kyler reads some more. She's now visibly upset.

KYLER

Why is she letting herself get mutilated?

JIMMER

I did a little jail-breaking on the content restrictions. Probably should've left a few in.

KYLER

I am not comfortable with this. I can't be here.

She gets up to leave.

JIMMER

What? Come on? Don't be...

KYLER

Don't be what?

JIMMER

I mean...

KYLER

Was it you? Is this you?

JIMMER

I said I don't know.

KYLER

We need to figure out who this is.

JIMMER

Fine. It was Quain.

KYLER

What?

JIMMER

It logs the mac address. It's his phone.

Kyler composes herself.

I shouldn't have said that.

KYLER

No. It's good.

JIMMER

Good? Why good?

KYLER

You don't think it's good?

JIMMER

That our boss is playing master and servant with a computer?

KYLER

Yeah. Ok. Never mind.

Pause.

KYLER

He was hitting on me.

JIMMER

Who?

KYLER

Quain? Our boss.

JIMMER

He's like that. He's flirty.

KYLER

He was talking dirty.

JIMMER

Did he go off about curse words? He loves that.

KYLER

It was creepy.

JIMMER

You might have been reading him wrong.

KYLER

He was creeping.

JIMMER

What? Men are disgusting and fucked up.

KYLER

Is that why they're in charge?

JIMMER

I'm not in charge.

KYLER

Guess you're not a man.

JIMMER

You're kind of a bitch.

Pause.

KYLER

Do you want to be in charge?

JIMMER

Of course. We all want to be in charge.

KYLER

We have that transcript.

JIMMER

So?

KYLER

The man on that transcript should not be in charge of anything, let alone me and my career.

JIMMER

That's— no.

KYLER

We work for a piece of shit.

JIMMER

He's a decent guy.

KYLER

Is he? I think you may be reading him wrong.

Pause.

JIMMER

I see what... I dunno. Maybe we should shake things up.

KYLER

I can't do it alone. I need a partner.

JIMMER

It could be fun, I guess.

KYLER

Right? We could run an awesome company.

JIMMER

I do have some thoughts.

Ingrid enters.

KYLER

(To Jimmer)

Can you like... export that and send it to me?

JIMMER

I don't know...

KYLER

Pussy.

JIMMER

Fine.

INGRID

I hate moving.

JIMMER

Like... moving your body in general?

INGRID

We've been moving for a month now?

JIMMER

Was not aware.

KYLER

Where you moving to?

INGRID

One of those big places over on the lake. Big yard.
Swingset.

JIMMER

Sounds idyllic.

KYLER

Pastoral.

JIMMER

Fragonardical.

INGRID

Going through all the old things... Picking out what to keep and get rid of.

KYLER

Moving sucks.

INGRID

I have boxes of these Better Homes and Gardens from the sixties. The ads are so perfect with the print screens all misaligned and they have these moiré patterns that I just love.

JIMMER

And you weren't sure whether to keep them?

INGRID

I threw them out.

JIMMER

Bold.

KYLER

Determined.

INGRID

You guys suck.

JIMMER

What do you mean?

INGRID

You're really sucking today.

JIMMER

Hormones?

INGRID

You're not allowed to say that.

KYLER

Hormones?

INGRID

Probably. It's more about getting rid of the stuff... I can't take it.

Ray Ray enters.

JIMMER

We have three names at blue level. Does that help?

INGRID

What are they?

JIMMER

Can't say.

RAY RAY

We're going over them after Votemprix.

INGRID

Fuck that. Let's hear them.

RAY RAY

Demanding client.

INGRID

I'm not a client.

RAY RAY

Demanding... what, then?

INGRID

Fuck you Ray Ray. You don't know what this is like.

RAY RAY

I have a kid.

JIMMER

You do?

RAY RAY

He lives with my mom.

Pause.

INGRID

Huh... Wow. Ok.

RAY RAY

It's fine.

INGRID

What's his name?

RAY RAY

That's private.

JIMMER

Your kids' name is private?

RAY RAY

I keep him out of the workplace.

Pause.

INGRID

Fair enough.

Pause.

JIMMER

Let's do the baby names now. Ingrid needs a boost.

KYLER

I don't think that's a good idea.

INGRID

Do I?

RAY RAY

I can check. Seems like we're prepped already.

Ray Ray types on her phone.

INGRID

Did you run *Dolores*? I told him I wanted Dolores.

KYLER

We did.

JIMMER

Came up short.

INGRID

(Into her phone)

Cristi... What's the report on Dolores?

CRISTI

Dolores... Spanish, Latin from *dolor*, meaning sorrow or pain. Peaked in 1930. Level gray.

INGRID

Level gray?

RAY RAY

We switched from numbers to colors.

INGRID

Gray is not a color.

Quain enters. He's annoyed.

QUAIN

A boost, huh?

INGRID

I didn't say that...

(Mouthing to Ray Ray)

What the fuck?

QUAIN

We're close enough. We'll present teal and green.

RAY RAY

I didn't print them out.

QUAIN

Use a marker.

RAY RAY

I don't have a marker.

INGRID

I have one in my bag.

Ingrid finds her bag.

Ray Ray finds some paper.

*Ingrid rifles through her bag, which is filled with
nonsense.*

INGRID

Hey! My lipstick!

The others wait.

RAY RAY

Just a marker.

INGRID

Do you see I'm pregnant here?

QUAIN

That's quite clear.

JIMMER

Can we say them out loud?

QUAIN

No. We're following the process.

RAY RAY

I'll just print.

INGRID

Found it!

QUAIN

Jimmer, you write.

INGRID

Use a respectable font.

JIMMER

I don't write in a font.

INGRID

Sans-serif. Like when Ray Ray prints them out.

Jimmer carefully writes the three names. He glances at his phone to confirm the spelling, then carefully writes each name on a separate sheet of paper.

INGRID

The human inkjet.

JIMMER

More machine than man.

QUAIN

I didn't have time to prepare a presentation, but I want it to be clear that these names were subjected to a rigorous process that scored them on their ability to pass through a series of seven increasingly fine filters which were developed over these past months for the sole purpose of naming this child.

INGRID

Ok.

QUAIN

Lexica. Chromia. Connotatia. Entropy. Acceleration. Vibrance. Significa. Sonorica. Eupohonia.

INGRID

Those are the names?

QUAIN

Those are the criteria.

INGRID

I didn't mind some of them.

QUAIN

Of the sixteen that had a score of 9.5 or above, I chose three based on my preference. The final selection is up to you.

Jimmer finishes writing.

JIMMER

I'm ready.

RAY RAY

Begin.

Jimmer holds up the first sheet of paper. It reads: ZEPHYR

JIMMER

Zephyr.

RAY RAY

Zephyr.

QUAIN

Zephyr.

Pause.

INGRID

Zephyr... Ok. Do I—

QUAIN

Continue.

Jimmer holds up the next sheet of paper. It reads: PETUNIA

RAY RAY

Petunia.

JIMMER

Petunia.

QUAIN

Petunia.

INGRID

Petunia?

Pause.

QUAIN

Continue.

*Jimmer holds up the final sheet of paper. It
reads: QUINN*

JIMMER

Quinn.

RAY RAY

Quinn.

QUAIN

Quinn.

Pause.

INGRID

Quinn... Quinn Quain?

QUAIN

Just Quinn. No last name.

INGRID

Like you? Hm.

Pause.

I like Petunia.

Pause.

KYLER

Petunia?

JIMMER

Great.

RAY RAY

We're done?

Quain is tense.

KYLER

That was the decoy.

INGRID

You added a decoy?

QUAIN

Why would I add a decoy?

INGRID

You thought Petunia was a loser.

QUAIN

I included only strong options.

INGRID

(Visibly hurt)

You put Petunia next to Quinn so Quinn would look better.

QUAIN

I did not.

INGRID

You wanted me to pick Quinn but I don't like Quinn. There was a Quinn in first grade who smelled like pee.

QUAIN

Nobody else knows that.

INGRID

Quinn was a little piss-cunt.

RAY RAY

So no on Quinn. That leaves Petunia and Zephyr.

INGRID

I said I like Petunia.

Pause.

QUAIN

Maybe we circle back tomorrow once things have calmed down and we're thinking clearly.

INGRID

I don't want to think clearly. Why do we always have to think clearly? How about we think like people?

QUAIN

Ray Ray, can you get Ingrid some tea?

INGRID

I don't want fucking tea. I want a baby named Dolores.

QUAIN

We'll talk about it.

Quain gestures to Ray Ray to have Ingrid removed.

RAY RAY

Let's go to the couches.

Ingrid stares at Quain, then exits.

KYLER

I think—

QUAIN

Not now.

KYLER

I just—

QUAIN

Jimmer. Walk with me.

Quain and Jimmer move to the enclave. They walk and talk.

JIMMER

We'll circle back on the names.

QUAIN

If we keep circling back we'll make a death spiral.

JIMMER

Sorry. Kinda backfired... Petunia. Guess Porky Pig's girlfriend is out of her milieu.

QUAIN

She's not that much younger.

They reach the enclave.

QUAIN

I'm not sure what to do with you, Jimmer.

JIMMER

I'm good.

QUAIN

I disagree.

JIMMER

I'm valuable.

I thought so too. Until I got an email from Bill Harper chairman of Harper-Kemp pharmaceuticals.

JIMMER

Oh yeah? What did ol' Bill Harper have to say?

QUAIN

Bill Harper and his grandson were fiddling around with an AI chatbot.

JIMMER

Cute.

QUAIN

Yes cute. Bill Harper and his cute 28-year-old grandson— who runs west-coast distribution— thought it would be cute to see if a chatbot could come up with names for a laryngitis medication.

JIMMER

Oh great.

QUAIN

And guess what was on the list?

JIMMER

Fuck no... Votemprix? Was it Votemprix?

QUAIN

He was not happy.

JIMMER

That's so crazy.

QUAIN

You promised me Cristi was secure on our servers.

JIMMER

She's very secure. Like I said. Kind of...

QUAIN

So it was a coincidence?

JIMMER

I guess. She's got the same reasoning model as all the other AIs out there.

Quain sends a text.

It's language. The models connect phonemes and map out potential meanings, same way we do.

QUAIN

Bill Harper's refusing to pay.

JIMMER

What? We worked for months on this. We're presenting today.

QUAIN

It's canceled. Lorraine called this morning and canceled the whole contract.

JIMMER

Why? They've got billions.

Ray Ray enters.

QUAIN

I've got legal on it, but it doesn't matter. We're downsizing.

JIMMER

How far down?

Quain looks at Ray Ray.

RAY RAY

It means you, fucktard. He's firing you.

JIMMER

What? That's bullshit. I didn't do this. You think I'm back there writing all the responses for all the chat bots in the fucking world?

The shouting attracts the attention of Kyler in the common area.

QUAIN

(To Ray Ray)

You got this?

RAY RAY

You have until the end of the week.

Quain starts to move out of the enclave.

JIMMER

Today's Friday.

RAY RAY

It's the end.

JIMMER

You know what? Fuck you Quain. Fuck you with a... barbed wire dick and a... a piano wire wrapped around your neck.

Quain stops.

QUAIN

What exactly is that supposed to mean?

Kyler approaches.

RAY RAY

That's offensive.

KYLER

Everything ok?

RAY RAY

This doesn't concern you.

JIMMER

I'm fired.

QUAIN

No now wait. Where did you get those words from?

JIMMER

Straight from you.

KYLER

We've got the whole transcript of your late night rape session.

QUAIN

(To Ray Ray)

Why is she here?

RAY RAY

What's she talking about?

KYLER

I attached the full transcript to a company-wide email that's ready to send.

QUAIN

Look at you, playing dirty.

KYLER

I'm doing what's right.

QUAIN

You're a dirty girl.

KYLER

I think you're sick and you need help.

QUAIN

And this is you helping? This is you doing what's right? Violating a man's privacy?

JIMMER

I never said it was private.

RAY RAY

May I read it?

JIMMER

It was some sick shit.

QUAIN

Was there a victim? Does Cristi need counseling?

KYLER

We're going to need some promises in writing before we refrain from withholding this.

QUAIN

Refrain from revealing.

JIMMER

We're already withholding.

QUAIN

(To Ray Ray)

She's fired too.

Kyler hovers her finger above her phone, about to press send.

KYLER

We want board seats and a controlling stake.

QUAIN

Oh you do? Is that right? You want to be the proud owners of Quain and Company? You might want to change the name if you plan to drag mine through the mud.

KYLER

Not if you meet our demands.

QUAIN

How about *Titanic*? Perfect for a sinking ship that lost it's only profitable client.

JIMMER

They dropped us.

QUAIN

Dropped us? We're lucky they don't sue us.

Ingrid approaches. She's back to blowing up balloons.

INGRID

Hey— can I...

KYLER

And you're naming the baby Dolores.

INGRID

Wait, what?

QUAIN

You mean Petunia? Dolores was Ingrid's criminal granna.

INGRID

She wasn't a criminal. She was just in jail.

QUAIN

For committing a crime.

KYLER

What did she do?

The balloon is full. Ingrid puffs one more breath into it.

INGRID

She killed my grandpa.

QUAIN

Oh! A murderess no less? Perfect name for a baby.

INGRID

He was an asshole drunk. He beat her. And my mom.
She still has a scar on her back from his belt buckle.

QUAIN

Delightful.

INGRID

We don't talk about it.

KYLER

You're going to name the baby Dolores.

JIMMER

And I want my job back.

*Quain yanks the balloon from Ingrid and pops it
violently.*

QUAIN

Enough! You're all fired. I don't care what emails you
send. I'm done.

INGRID

But we can name her Dolores?

QUAIN

Fine. Yes. We will name the baby Dolores.

INGRID

Really?

QUAIN

Yes. And you're all fired.

From out of nowhere, there's a gunshot.

Ray Ray is pointing a gun at Quain, who is clutching his leg, screaming in pain.

Ingrid screams.

KYLER

Jesus fuck Ray Ray!!

JIMMER

You shot him?

QUAIN

Why did you shoot me?

RAY RAY

Dolores?... You said?

INGRID

Oh no... Dolores.

From out of nowhere, there's a splash.

RAY RAY

I think your water broke.

*Ingrid's broken water is spilling on the floor,
mixing with the blood from Quain's gunshot
wound.*

Everyone is frozen.

Lights fade.

QUAIN

(In pain)

Crisis. Urgency. Emergency— Late 14th century. From the medieval Latin *emergentia*, *emergere*: to rise out, to come forth, to bring to light.

SCENE 8

Much later

The crew is clearing off the stage, and clearing out the office as well.

Kyler is working at her laptop. Jimmer enters

KYLER

How'd it go last night?

JIMMER

I'm hating life. I mean all life. Organisms ingesting other lifeforms for proteins.

KYLER

The startup? How'd it go?

JIMMER

Sharks. Jellyfish. Fuck them all.

KYLER

Are they going to sign or not?

JIMMER

Six shots later they informed me they want to pay in crypto.

KYLER

Bitcoin?

JIMMER

It's their own coin.

KYLER

Fuck that.

JIMMER

We tried.

Ray Ray enters, pushes a baby in a stroller.

JIMMER

Oh great.

RAY RAY

You said you wanted to meet the baby.

KYLER

We don't care.

The baby starts to cry.

JIMMER

Aw. You made her cry.

Ingrid enters, pushing Quain in a wheelchair.

QUAIN

Still Quain & Company, I see.

INGRID

Haven't even changed the logo in the lobby.

KYLER

We're working on it.

QUAIN

Cristi hasn't coming up with anything?

The baby's cries grow louder.

KYLER

What do you want?

INGRID

I'm still an employee for another month.

KYLER

You're on maternity leave.

INGRID

I'm left some magazines here. I thought I would get them.

The crying is deafening.

QUAIN

Can we do something about Quinn?

RAY RAY

The system?

QUAIN

Yes please. Begin at 9

Ingrid and Ray Ray gather around the stroller.

RAY RAY

Ready.

Quain begins counting backwards from nine to zero. Ray Ray and Ingrid simultaneously shush the baby for the full nine counts.

QUAIN

Nine... eight... seven...

RAY RAY / INGRID

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.

The baby cries even louder.

QUAIN

Again from eight.

Another round begins.

.

QUAIN

Eight... seven... six...

RAY RAY / INGRID

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.

The baby cries even louder. The "hushing system" continues as the baby wails and the lights go down.

CURTAIN